Torching

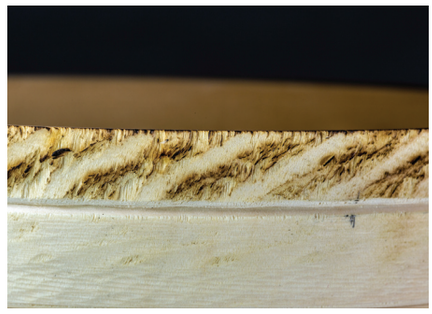
Torching sounds a bit brutal but in reality that is what is going on. The use of a torch needs to be done with care, both how it is done and where it is done. The beauty of the torch is that you can 'draw' with it. Depending on where it is presented and how, you can create minor colouration accents to features that have been carved into the turning. You can also use the torch to contour the wood to take on any shaping that you wish. There are a host of torches that can be brought to bear for this process. Very few of us will have access to multi-gas industrial-grade torches but most of us have a home shop propane torch. Even if you don't currently have one, they are very modestly priced and available from DIY shops and discount tool shops. Another useful torch for more focused results is the mini-butane torches available to the artist. The flame on these units can be very fine and burns very hot. You can literally write with this flame. From my experience, I don't use any torch by itself. I always use this kind of flame in conjunction with another process. Usually I accent edges, cut in features, or carving that has been done. Torching can be done on green wood but it is quite variable. I find that dried wood works best but care needs to be taken to control the effects. Keeping a wetted cloth to stop the effect exactly where it is planned works well.

Key points

- Torch in a fire-safe area and have proper extinguisher equipment ready.
- Green wood burns very differently to dry wood.
- A wetted cloth allows for precise control of burn areas.
- Use proper hand protection when using a torch.
- Preplan. Mark out your plan or enhance prior modifications.

Depending on your size and dexterity needs, you can use anything from the propane torch to micro butane torches

The pencil butane torch has a much smaller nozzle but still packs plenty of heat



Some practice light accenting on a rim. Ragged textures or delineated edges show the best

Denting and dinging

When you think of denting and dinging, there are a multitude of tools that can be used and even more surface modifications that can be made. Rather than the ultra-smooth, nicely sanded surface, you can create the dinged and dented markings that will draw some interest. Not only will they draw interest but they can also put your work into the various styles that feature 'distressing'. I think of the desert southwest of the United States for its rather unique distressed Mission-style furniture. The surface flaws in the wood lend an air of years of use even when the piece is brand new. Being able to present the picture of generations of age with something just created is a very interesting treatment. Two simple methods for doing this is a hammer and punch and an impact scaler. The hammer and punch couldn't be simpler. A hammer striking a properly positioned punch to mar the surface and then moving it to the next location is all that is needed. If you don't have a patterned punch, feel free to create one or use anything that will safely accept hammer impact and impart texture to the wood surface. Another tool that will perform this feat is a rust scaler. I have an air-driven version that is used to remove rust or welding scale from steel. With the round nosed steel needles, it will create surface dimpling when applied to wood. It is especially effective when applied to wood that has been painted. This will flaw the wood right through the paint creating a well-used feeling.

Key points

- A simple hammer and flat punch will allow distressing.
- Be certain your punch is safe for hammer impact.
- The effect varies dramatically with species and grain orientation.
- Nails, prick punches, drift punches and filed face drill rod will work.
- Experiment on a practice piece before committing to the final work.
- A method of sectioning off will help with visual impact.

A pneumatic scaling tool will create some interesting patterns when applied to wood

RIGHT: Like the texturing tools, speeds and feeds along with grain and species will impact results

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